

Figure 1: Selecting files and folders for file system backup

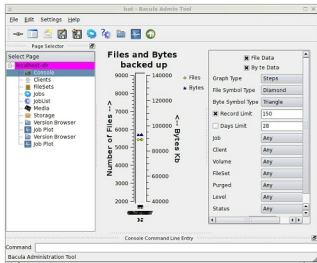


Figure 2: Bacula admin page

instead of having you schedule them. It's also the only open source package to have database agents for SQL Server, Exchange, SharePoint and Oracle, as well as the only backup package to have an agent for MySQL and Ingress.

Amanda is now backed by Zmanda, and this company has put its development into overdrive. Just a few months after beginning operations, Zmanda has addressed major limitations in the product that had hindered it for years. Since then, it has been responsible for the addition of a lot of functionality, including those database agents.

Bacula

Bacula was originally written by Kern Sibbald, who chose a very different path from Amanda by writing a custom backup format designed to overcome the limitations of the native tools. Sibbald's original goal was to write a tool that could take the place of the enterprise tools he saw in the data centre.

Bacula also has scheduling, automation and tracking of all backups, allowing you to easily restore any file (or files) from a previous version. Like Amanda, it also has media management features that allow you to use automated tape libraries and perform disk-to-disk backups.

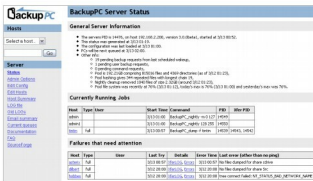


Figure 3: BackupPC server status

As of this writing, Bacula is only a file backup product and does not provide any database agents. You can shut a database down and back up its files, but this is not a viable backup method for some databases.

BackupPC

Both Amanda and Bacula feel and behave like conventional backup products. They have support for both disk and tape, scheduled full and incremental backups, and they come in a 'backup format'. BackupPC, on the other hand, is a disk-only backup tool that forever performs incremental backups, and stores those backups in their native format in a snapshot-like tree structure that is available via a GUI. Like Bacula, it's a file-only backup tool and its incremental nature might be hampered by backing up large database files. However, it's a really interesting alternative for file data. BackupPC's single most imposing feature is that it does file-level de-duplication. If you have a file duplicated anywhere in your environment, it will find that duplicate and replace it with a link to the original file.

Which one should you use?

Choosing a data backup tool entirely depends on the purpose. If you want the least proprietary backup format then go for BackupPC. If database agents are a big driver, you can choose Amanda. Or if you want a product that's designed like a typical commercial backup application, then opt for Bacula. One more important aspect is that both BackupPC and Amanda need the Linux server to control backup and Bacula has a Windows server to do the same.

All three products are very popular. Which one you choose depends on what you need. The really nice thing about all three tools is that they can be downloaded free of cost. So you can decide which one is better for you after trying out all three. 

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